Twas a Dark and Dreary Night

By Patrick F. McManus

Back during my single-digit ages, I often thought about running away and joining the French Foreign Legion. The uniform was nice, and I liked the idea of riding horses and camels across the desert. Only one thing bothered me. I wondered if the Legionnaires were issued night lights. My love of adventure had its limits. I could easily imagine a battle-hardened Legionnaire sergeant reporting to his company commander, "Looks grim, sir. We've run out of food and water and the ammunition's nearly gone. Worse yet, we're short on fuel fro the men's night lights." With my luck, I'd be the one whose night light ran out of fuel first.

INTRODUCTION

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I realized of course that fear of darkness was a serious flaw in my character. Since my character was riddled with flaws anyway, I didn't worry much about one more. Nevertheless, I didn't want my friends to find out I was afraid of the dark, and I went to great lengths to keep my secret from them. Take, for instance, the time Ronnie Ditmire came out to our farm to spend the night with me.

Ronnie had no sooner set foot in the house than he came up with the suggestion that he and I sleep out in the backyard. He said he'd had a lot of experience sleeping out in backyards in town, but this was his first opportunity to do so in the country.

"Yeah, well," I said. "Sure. In the dark, you mean. Sleep out. That would be

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fun. You don't mind a lot of black widow spiders crawling all over you, do you Ronnie?"

"You got black widow spiders in your yard?"

Patting my hair back down, I retracted a few premature goosebumps. Unfortunately, my evil sister, the Troll, overheard our conversation and rushed to put in her oar and roil the waters. "What are you telling Ronnie? There are no black widow spiders in our yard, you silly!"

"Ma!" the Troll roared. "Are there any black widow spiders in the yard?"

Mom, ever ready to rush to my defense, stuck her head out of the kitchen. "No, of course not. Where did you ever get a dumb idea like that?"

"I thought there were," I said smiling weakly at Ronnie.

"Good," he said. "Then we can sleep out in the yard tonight, after all.."

"I can't think of any reason why not," I said. "Unless you happen to beothered by poisonous snakes. Ever seen anybody get snakebit? First they swell up into a great big horrible ball, and then they turn blue and green and yellow and then it starts to get real bad."

"My dad says there ain't any poisonous snakes around here," Ronnie said. "So we don't have to worry about snakes."

"I thought we did," I said.

"OF course not," the Troll put in. "There aren't any poisonous snakes around here – not even when it's dark! (Trollish cackle)

"Ma!" I yelled. "The Troll is bothering us. Tell her to leave us alone!"

"Don't refer to your sister as the Troll," my mother said. "Now, Trudy, get out of there and leave the boys alone."

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The Troll backed slowly out of the room, grinning evilly. "Hope you have a good time sleeping out – in – the – dark. The weather report says there's going to be heavy darkness all night (cackle cackle!)

Just my luck – heavy darkness. And here was Ronnie, pressing ahead with his plan for sleeping out. This was getting out of hand. We were actually getting some old blankets and quilts down out of the attic to make a bed in the yard. What madness! I considered asking Ronnie to take an oath of secrecy and then confessing to him my disgusting fear of darkness. He would probably understand.

"I'll tell you something weird," Ronnie said. "I tried to get Fred Phelps to sleep out with me one night, and he said he couldn't, he was afraid of the dark. A big guy like Fred, you wouldn't expect him to be yellow-bellied chicken, would ya? He even made me take a secret oath not to tell anybody."

"Fred's dumb too." I said. So much for that idea.

Darkness was already coming down off the mountain, crawling out of the woods, and oozing up from the creek bottom. Down in the swamp, a chorus of frogs welcomed the coming of night. Stupid frogs.

The Troll detected my fear of darkness early on, and used it for her own amusement. Once, walking home with her through the woods, I noticed that the shadows of the trees had lengthened and were not blending together into great patches of – darkness. "It's getting dark!" I warned. "We'd better run. We don't want to get caught out here after dark."

The Troll stopped, turned around, and studied me thoughtfully. "We can't run," she said. "If we run, the wolves will attack."

I looked around, as one is wont to do after such an announcement. "What

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wolves?"

"The wolves that have been following us," she said. "Don't tell me you haven't seen them!"

Well, now that she mentioned it, I did indeed see the wolves, slipping along through the shadows to the left and right of us.

The Troll clamly studied my reaction. "Why are you twisting yourself all up like that, you silly?"

Apparently she had never before seen anybody wind up the main spring. Sprannnnnggggg! And I was gone. At the time, I knew nothing about the infectious nature of panic. Otherwise I wouldn't have been so surprised when, upon reaching my top crusing speed, I noticed the Troll passing me on the left and still accelerating, her braids snapping like bullwhips as she cut in front of me. Maybe she thought there actually were wolves following us. More than likely it was simply that panic loves company. For my part, I couldn't have cared less about a mere pack of wolves. A pack of wolves wasn't even in the same league as a pack of darkness.

But now here were Ronnie and I, engaged in the insanity of actually spreading quilts and blankets on top of an old hay tarp in preparation for spending the night outdoors. If I even relaxed my feigned enthusiasm for the undertaking – good word that, undertaking – Ronnie would become suspicious. Then both Fred Phelps and I would become outcasts at school next fall, when Ronnie spread the word that we two yellow-bellied chickens were scared of the dark.

Of course, all I need was a tiny little night light. Something the size of a birthday-cake candle would do – a fifteen-foot birthday-cake candle. Any obvious

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night light, though, would cause Ronnie to put some tough questions to me, like, "What you doing with that flashlight and the big stack of batteries?" Even if I'd had a big stack of batteries, I couldn't have risked it.

"What say we turn in?" Ronnie asked. "it's already dark."

"I noticed," I said.

I glanced longingly up at our house, the lights of which were being flicked off one by one as my mother made her final rounds. She opened the back door and called out, "I'm going to bed now. You boys all right?"

"Yep," Ronnie said.

"Yaup," I said.

Mom went back inside, and minutes later the last light on our side of the house flicked off. Ronnie and I were in TOTAL DARKNESS! Not just the well-defined cube of darkness that filled a bedroom, but a great shapeless ocean of night!

"You ever hear the story about the stranger who got himself hung for claim-jumping, and his ghost still wanders these parts looking for revenge?" Ronnie said.

"Yeah, I heard it."

"Well, my pa seen that ghost crossing a field right out this way one night. Foggy it was he said, and . . . "

Idea! Why hadn't I thought of it before! I leaped out of the covers and told Ronnie I'd be right back. "I forgot to brush my teeth," I said, rushing toward the house. In the bathroom, I jerked the string on the overhead light, waited an appropriate length of time, and then sauntered back outside. Perfect! The light from the bathroom window cast a nice rectangular patch of light right next to my

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side of the hay tarp.

"You left the bathroom light on," Ronnie said.

"Dang," I said. "If that doesn't beat all! Oh, well, a little light won't hurt anything."

Without warning, an ominous shadow suddenly appeared in my patch of light. Wha? I turned and looked up at the bathroom window. No! There, framed in the window stood the Troll! She was in silhouette, so I couldn't see her face, but I knew she was grinning her evil grin as she stared down in my direction. Slowly her hand reached for the light string. NO! DON'T DO IT! She made several teasing motions with the light string, then – Zap! The light was gone. Faintly, off in the darkness, I could hear the hollow wound of trollish laughter. She would have already locked all the doors to the house. Trolls are nothing if not thorough.

So now there was nothing to do but suffer the night away. For me, the Troll had murdered any hope of sleep. Under my breath I put a curse on her: May a garter snake turn up in your underwear drawer! (And a garter snake would, which show you can't discount the power of curses) - Trollish cackle . . . .

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